CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

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RE: AUKUS scrap-it inquiry brands pact 'worst defence decision' · PNG wharf blast identified as Chinese artillery round · NZ jobless at 11-year high, 3 days from vote · Fiji military opposes coup immunity · RBA lifts rate for fifth time in 2026

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
8,834	0.7014	13,783	0.5632
-0.14%	-0.62%	+0.67%	+0.05%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · AUKUS · Pacific · New Zealand · China-Pacific · Canberra · Markets · Upcoming · The Wire

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. A crowd-funded inquiry led by **Peter Garrett** and retired defence chief **Chris Barrie** calls for AUKUS to be scrapped, branding the $368 billion submarine pact Australia's worst and riskiest defence decision.
2. Papua New Guinea police identify a Port Moresby wharf explosive as an undetonated Chinese Type 59 artillery round, contradicting Beijing's embassy claim that the object was a wine bottle.
3. New Zealand's jobless rate hits an eleven-year high three days before the November 7 election, undercutting **Christopher Luxon**'s closing economic pitch as he tours from the Hutt Valley to Auckland by bus.

TOP STORIES

AUKUS

Crowd-funded inquiry led by Garrett and Barrie calls for AUKUS to be scrapped

A public inquiry into the AUKUS submarine pact, titled "Surrendering Australia: the Aukus Deception," calls the plan "the worst, riskiest and most costly defence decision ever made by an Australian government" and demands termination. Former Labor minister **Peter Garrett** led the crowd-funded inquiry; retired Chief of the Defence Force **Chris Barrie** served as a commissioner and warned Australia must not blindly follow the United States. The report puts the pact at *$368 billion*, with the first Virginia-class boat due in Australia in 2032.

per SMH Federal Politics: "Former defence chief urges rethink of Australia's relationship with China" · also ABC News

CHINA-PACIFIC

PNG police identify Port Moresby wharf device as Chinese artillery round, contradicting embassy

Papua New Guinea police and military explosives experts identified a device found in a commercial shipping container at a major Port Moresby wharf as an undetonated *130mm* Chinese Type 59 artillery round, high-level sources told the ABC, in a police report finalised today. The Chinese Embassy in Port Moresby posted on Tuesday that a company linked to the incident had conducted an "on-site verification" and found the object was "in fact a shell-shaped wine bottle." Four Chinese nationals were arrested on Friday.

per RNZ Pacific (Marian Faa): "Chinese embassy suggests explosive found at PNG wharf a 'wine bottle' that 'poses no danger'"

NZ-POLITICS

New Zealand jobless rate hits 11-year high three days before the election

New Zealand's unemployment rate climbed in the third quarter to its highest level in eleven years, landing three days before the November 7 general election. Bloomberg and the Wall Street Journal carried the same figures, with the cost of living already dominating the campaign. **Christopher Luxon** spent Wednesday on a three-day National Party bus tour from the Hutt Valley to Auckland, telling voters to "stick to the plan" and avoid strategic-voting "malarkey."

per Reuters: "New Zealand jobless rate hits 11-year high in run-up to polls" · also Bloomberg

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Fiji military opposes coup immunity provisions in constitution bill

The Republic of Fiji Military Forces told a Special Parliamentary Committee it opposes new immunity provisions for coup makers in the government's Constitution (Amendment) Bill. Prime Minister **Sitiveni Rabuka**, who led the 1987 coup, told the same committee that Fiji relies on the military to maintain law and order during "disruptions" and has signalled possible intervention "if things don't go right." Commander Kalouniwai said the RFMF did not appear with "clean hands" and that past coups rested on an "architecture of rebellion" of secrecy, fear, personal loyalty, and constitutional immunity.

per RNZ Pacific: "Fiji military chief urges accountability to the people amid coup immunity debate"

OVERNIGHT

US-AUSTRALIA

Chalmers says Australians are 'cost-of-living casualties' of decisions in Washington and Tehran · ABC Politics

Treasurer **Jim Chalmers** warned of economic consequences for Australia as US midterm results came in, saying Australians are "the cost-of-living casualties of decisions taken in D.C. and Tehran." The comment followed the Reserve Bank's fifth rate rise of 2026, with Governor **Michelle Bullock** warning Australians will feel poorer. Attention now turns to the upcoming MYEFO.

US-AUSTRALIA

Democrats take both chambers of Congress in US midterms · ABC News

Democrats flipped the House of Representatives and the Senate, taking seats in Texas, Ohio, Kansas, Iowa, Maine, North Carolina, and South Carolina. The ABC's analysis described an emphatic defeat for **Donald Trump** while cautioning that the president retains veto power and is no lame duck. Australian officials now face a Congress in which committee control over defence authorisations has changed hands.

AU-POLITICS

Australia tells court its under-16 social media ban protects children's brains · Washington Post

The Commonwealth argued in court that the under-16 social media ban is needed to protect children's developing brains, defending the measure against a constitutional challenge. The High Court began hearing the challenge this week. The case determines whether Canberra can hold the line on a restriction other governments are watching.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Queensland and NT governments block UN rapporteur from youth detention visits · ABC News

The United Nations says its special rapporteur investigating human rights issues affecting Indigenous Australians has been refused access to two youth detention centres by the Queensland and Northern Territory governments. The refusal falls to the Commonwealth to explain internationally, since the visit was arranged through the UN system.

STAT OF THE DAY

$368B

Cost of the AUKUS submarine pact as cited by the Garrett inquiry

The crowd-funded inquiry calls the programme the costliest defence decision ever made by an Australian government and demands its termination.

ABC News

AUKUS WATCH

PILLAR 1 · ABC POLITICS

Barrie tells ABC the inquiry found the submarine plan unaffordable and unsound

Retired Admiral **Chris Barrie**, a former Chief of the Defence Force and a commissioner on the crowd-funded inquiry, set out its case on ABC Radio National. The report records the first Virginia-class submarine from the United States as due to arrive in Australia in 2032. The AUKUS milestone tracker carries no confirmed Virginia-class delivery date, and the government has not responded to the report.

PACIFIC WIRE

FIJI · FBC NEWS (FIJI)

Fiji concentrates maritime security inside 12 nautical miles, citing capacity limits

Defence Minister **Pio Tikoduadua** told Parliament that limited surveillance and operational capacity is forcing Fiji to prioritise security operations within *12 nautical miles* of its coastline. He said Fiji must make strategic choices about where to deploy available assets across a vast maritime territory.

SOLOMON ISLANDS · ABC PACIFIC

Australia to build eastern border patrol base at Vanikoro, Temotu premier says

Following the handover and opening of the new Santa Cruz Airport in Lata last Friday, the Solomon Islands government announced two further Temotu projects starting in 2027: an airport on Vanikoro, in the province's southeast near Vanuatu's Torba Province, and an Eastern Border Patrol Base. Temotu Premier Stanley Tehiahua said Australia will build the patrol base at Numbuko Bay on Vanikoro, and pressed for a proper wharf at the Lata provincial headquarters.

FIJI · ABC PACIFIC

Fiji teams up with New Zealand to review its intelligence structures

Fiji is working with New Zealand on a review of its intelligence architecture, ABC Pacific Beat reported. The review runs alongside the parliamentary fight over the Constitution (Amendment) Bill and the military's submission on coup immunity.

REGIONAL · ABC PACIFIC

Pacific states push new catch-limit procedures for bigeye tuna

Pacific nations are calling for new fishing limit procedures for bigeye tuna, ABC Pacific Beat reported. Tuna licence revenue underwrites national budgets across the north and central Pacific, which makes stock-setting rules a fiscal question as much as a conservation one.

REGIONAL · ABC PACIFIC

Guam ousts both its governor and its House delegate in the US midterms

Guam voters removed both the territory's governor and its delegate to the US House of Representatives, ABC Pacific Beat reported. Islands Business separately reported the Republican Ada-Calvo team winning Guam's gubernatorial race, and runoffs ahead in the Northern Marianas for the governorship and attorney-general.

SAMOA · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Samoa and Antigua and Barbuda demand fairer climate finance at CHOGM

Samoa joined Antigua and Barbuda in pressing Commonwealth leaders for fairer climate finance terms, while Fiji called for debt-free climate finance for small island states. PACNEWS also reports the current El Nino event is likely to intensify and persist through to March 2027.

VANUATU · ABC PACIFIC

Whooping cough and diarrhoea outbreaks reported on Ambae island

Health authorities are dealing with whooping cough and diarrhoea cases on Ambae island, ABC's Wantok program reported. Ambae's population has been repeatedly displaced by volcanic activity, leaving health services on the island thin.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

PNG Fire Service struggling to keep pace with nationwide bushfires

Papua New Guinea's Fire Service cannot keep up with bushfires burning across the country, ABC Pacific Beat reported. The fires follow weeks of smoke over Port Moresby and coincide with El Nino conditions forecast to persist into March 2027.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Rabuka warns SODELPA and NFP over Cabinet positions if they oppose constitution changes

PACNEWS reports Prime Minister Sitiveni Rabuka warning coalition partners SODELPA and the National Federation Party that their Cabinet positions are at risk if they oppose his Constitution (Amendment) Bill. A later bulletin reports Rabuka intends to bypass the parliamentary committee's recommendation.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

Peters calls the 2026 campaign the worst he has seen in 18 elections

Winston Peters, who has contested eighteen general elections, told Morning Report the campaign had "turned into, sadly, a circus," citing ice-cream polls and leaders flipping hamburgers during a cost-of-living crisis. He said New Zealand First had spoken to "tens of thousands" of voters against ACT's claimed 7,000, and that "we view this as the real poll coming."

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

Luxon runs a three-day bus tour from Petone to Auckland in the campaign's final push

Christopher Luxon boarded the National Party bus at Petone foreshore on Wednesday morning with **Nicola Willis** and **Chris Bishop**, opening a three-day run to Auckland. With polls tight, Luxon is urging voters against strategic-voting "malarkey" and asking them to let National "finish the job."

NZ-POLITICS · AFP

AFP profiles the centrist outsider who could hold the balance of power

AFP reports on the centrist figure positioned to become New Zealand's kingmaker after Saturday's vote. The Lowy Interpreter noted yesterday that the prospective power broker has no articulated foreign policy.

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · DEVELOPMENT FINANCE · PNG POST-COURIER

PNG minister says Chinese support underpins K200 billion economy target

Minister for National Planning and Monitoring Sir **Ano Pala** said Papua New Guinea's plan to build a *K200 billion* economy and create one million jobs by 2030 will get a major boost from Chinese development support. The Post-Courier item lists the China International Development Cooperation Agency and the Medium-Term Development Plan 2023-2027 among its references.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

RBA warns next year will feel like a recession as inflation fight extends six months

The Reserve Bank says inflation will take six months longer than expected to bring under control and that next year will feel like a recession, after lifting the cash rate for the fifth time in 2026. Governor **Michelle Bullock** told Australians they will feel poorer.

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Government loses control of the economic narrative after the budget

Nothing is sticking for the Albanese government, which lost control of the economic narrative soon after the budget was handed down, the Sydney Morning Herald reports. The assessment follows yesterday's Newspoll placing Labor's primary vote at its equal lowest.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

NSW Liberals face MP exodus as One Nation support surges

An exodus of sitting Liberal MPs is under way in New South Wales as One Nation support rises, ABC analysis found. The trend tracks the federal Coalition's problem under **Angus Taylor**, with One Nation also surging in

Victoria.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Human Rights Commission names the 'manosphere' as a leading security threat

The Australian Human Rights Commission has identified online male radicalisation networks rather than Islamist extremism as the leading domestic security threat, The Australian reports. The finding has already drawn critical commentary in the same masthead.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Police concede caution issued to MP Luke Gosling may have been mistaken identity

Police have admitted that a caution issued to federal MP **Luke Gosling** may have been a case of mistaken identity. Gosling holds the Northern Territory seat of Solomon for Labor.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

ABC analysis says the inflation political script is exhausted

After years of inflation pain the political script on both sides is tired and in need of a reset, ABC analysis argues, with neither government nor opposition offering voters a new frame. The piece lands the day after the RBA's fifth rate rise of the year.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · SMH

Canva cuts close to 1,300 jobs in an AI restructure

Canva is letting go of nearly *1,300* staff in a restructure the company attributes to artificial intelligence, the largest job cut at an Australian technology firm this year. The Australian reported chief executive **Melanie Perkins** describing it as the company's "hardest moment" and framing the change as refounding the company.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Energy ministers weigh a strategic power reserve against renewable shortfalls

Energy ministers are considering a strategic power reserve to guard reliability against renewable generation shortfalls, The Australian reports. The proposal would add a standing capacity mechanism to the national electricity market.

UPCOMING

NOV 7

New Zealand general election

A tight result decides whether National can govern again and which minor party holds the balance of power on foreign and defence policy.

MAR 2027

Current El Nino event forecast to intensify and persist

Extends drought and bushfire pressure across Fiji, Papua New Guinea, and the wider region into a second planting season.

THE WIRE

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

ASPI STRATEGIST

Amid official and uni discretion, Australia needs hubs that will critique China

ASPI argues that government and university caution has left a gap in Australian public debate on China that independent civil-society institutions should fill, invoking Willy Brandt's line that foreign policy is too important to be left to governments alone.

ASPI STRATEGIST

Australia should work to block Myanmar's Russian nuclear power plant

ASPI urges Canberra to work through ASEAN and the Quad to prevent construction of Myanmar's proposed Russia-backed nuclear power plant, arguing it would create serious regional proliferation and safety risks.

TRADE-ECONOMY

LOWY INTERPRETER

Vietnam's other trade deals could claim Washington's wins

Clauses in Vietnam's EFTA and CPTPP agreements could extend concessions Washington negotiated to European, Australian, and Japanese firms, the Lowy Interpreter argues.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

ABC PACIFIC

Can the Pacific deepen ties with Israel while championing decolonisation?

ABC Pacific examines the tension between growing Pacific engagement with Israel and the region's long-standing decolonisation advocacy. Israel joined the Pacific Islands Forum as a development partner in October.

ABC PACIFIC

Powerhouse Parramatta to house a major contemporary Maori waka

Sydney's new Powerhouse Parramatta museum opens this weekend with its first major contemporary Maori waka, hand built and led by Maori tattoo artist and designer Peter Elers. Programs manager Donita Vatuinaruku-Hulme said the museum has run a three-week opening festival celebrating Pacific culture.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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